

THE WRONG WIDOW

Progressive hints (separate packet)

Open one rung at a time when stuck. Hints teach method — they do not name the supportable widow.

Keep sealed-solution.pdf closed. These hints never include the sealed exhibit.

H1 — when stuck: Overwhelmed by dual claims / death paper naming Lydia

List what each claimant asserts in her own words — marriage date, death claim, and what would make her file look strong. Don't decide yet.

Teaches: Affidavits are assertions.

H2 — when stuck: Hasn't verified marriages or treats claims as proof

Find the marriage registers for the dates and counties each woman cites. Treat each register as a witness to a ceremony — not yet as the final law.

Teaches: Ceremony as recorded event.

H3 — when stuck: Accepts hospital death as settled / ignores muster

Pull both the hospital line and the company muster for the same man. Write down how each describes his fate. If they disagree, that disagreement is evidence.

Teaches: Records conflict; muster ≠ gospel.

H4 — when stuck: Stuck on death-certificate primacy (Lydia named)

A death register naming a wife tells you who the household presented as widow. Separately ask: was there an earlier marriage, and was it ever dissolved?

Teaches: Named widow ≠ only possible / supportable widow.

H5 — when stuck: Hasn't found postwar life / still thinks 1863 death

After the wartime papers, look for the soldier in later censuses in the county of the second marriage. Ask whether a man marked dead can still appear as head of household.

Teaches: Recorded death vs continued life on paper.

H6 — when stuck: Tempted by Corbin/Ashley divorce or unsure about dissolution

When a divorce decree looks close, compare every letter of both surnames to the couple you care about. Then check the search result that names your exact parties.

Teaches: Near-name ≠ same persons; use the negative search for the right couple.

H7 — when stuck: Confused by Silas Corbit hospital death

Same-ish surnames aren't identity. Match unit, age, and home county before merging two hospital lines.

Teaches: Require more than a shared name.

H8 — when stuck: Ready to commit but conflating ceremony with lawful status

Separate three questions: (1) Did each ceremony happen? (2) Did an earlier undissolved marriage still bind? (3) Who does the death paper name? Answer each from paper before you pick a supportable widow.

Teaches: Ceremony $\neq$ lawful; death naming $\neq$ marriage law.

Still stuck after H8? Commit your best adjudication from the three-question frame, then open the sealed solution.